SPHINX

A sphinx is a legendary monster with a human head and a lion's body. In ancient Egypt, where the idea originated, the head was usually a portrait of the reigning pharaoh. It also represented the sky god Horus. The Egyptians always pictured their kings as calm and stately, with wide-open, staring eyes. The lion's body - symbolizing courage - is crouched with its front feet outstretched.

From Egypt the idea of the sphinx spread to the Syrians and Phoenicians and finally to the Greeks. These peoples gave the creature the head and bust of a woman. They added an eagle's wings to represent majesty and a long serpent's tail to indicate wiliness. In later Greek literature, the sphinx was no monster, but a beautiful, wise and mysterious woman.

The Great Sphinx at Giza was carved in about 2600 BC. It stands near the three great pyramids, gazing across the Nile to the east. The head is a portrait of Khafre, a pharaoh of the Old Kingdom. Near the sphinx rises Khafre's tomb, the second of the three great pyramids.

EXERCISE 1: Find words or phrases in the passage which mean the same as:

	COLUMN A	COLUMN B
a)	imaginary animal, often made up of various animal or human parts	
b)	ruling; exercising the power and authority of a king or queen	
c)	having a graceful, imposing and formal appearance	
d)	looking outward in a fixed manner	
e)	bent down low with arms and legs pulled in	
f)	extended	
g)	supreme power and authority; grandeur	
h)	snake	
i)	craftiness; being cunning	
j)	clever; knowing	
k)	puzzling; being unexplained	
l)	be shaped by tools; be cut to form something	
m)	looking in a fixed way in wonder or in order to admire something	

EXERCISE 2: Choose the correct answer according to the passage.

1. According to the passage, Egyptian sphinxes . . . . . .

A) normally depicted the people's ruler
B) had the wings of an eagle
C) were more like a bust than a complete figure
D) were usually of the size of a lion
E) were found inside the tomb of a ruler

2. It is understood from the passage that sphinxes . . . . . .

A) were only common in Egypt
B) were always carved to resemble Khafre
C) were usually standing upright
D) became popular with several civilizations
E) became less intricate with time

3. It is clear from the passage that the Great Sphinx at Giza . . . . . .

A) can be found near the tomb of the pharaoh depicted on its head
B) is not a monster at all but a beautiful intelligent female
C) was carved by the sky god Horus
D) is the largest of all sphinxes in the world
E) appears in later Greek literature

EXERCISE 3: Complete the sentences by selecting words from Column B in EXERCISE 1.

1. My son woke up screaming and saying that a/an ..... had come out of his wardrobe. I convinced him that the purple, horned creature was purely imaginary.
2. The ..... disappearance of the first English settlers in North Carolina has never been explained. A colony had been set up in 1587, but in 1591, a returning settler found no trace of them.
3. The man had ..... bears, eagles and wolves out of logs and was selling his craftwork by the roadside.
4. Caught behind enemy lines, the two parachutists ..... down behind some bushes until dark.
5. Queen Cleopatra took her own life and died, according to recorded history, as a result of a bite from a poisonous .....